

"Honestly, I did not have to influence them... My role was to take on the responsibility to implement the project, and I just grabbed the opportunity." If the senior management at all organisations were as well informed as those at ITM, there would be no stopping the deployment of FOSS. The confidence in free software runs deeper today than ever before. In fact, when it comes to trust, GNU/Linux is considered the best suitor when compared to proprietary technologies, as today, organisations are interested not only in something that is merely available and that functions, but also in how the solution works in the back-end and how much control they have over it. This is unlikely in a proprietary solution where you are at the mercy of the vendor.

Bhavsar says, "Cost is just one good reason for using open source software. Freedom from vendor lock-in gives us more flexibility to change to the best-in-class software as and when required. For example, we started with MySQL as the database for our ERP, but changed to PostgreSQL as the volume grew, and speed and reliability became critical."

When asked specifically about the cost savings due to migration, he shares, "We have never quantified it, but we would have conservatively saved Rs 600,000 to Rs 800,000 per annum on an average. There are over 100 desktops running Fedora, and more than 500 students accessing at least four servers (proxy, data, RADIUS and Intranet running on separate machines). There are other servers for LDAP, DHCP and the NAS."

But it was not all a bed of roses. "While the management was pro-GNU/Linux, the staff was sceptical. We struggled for the first two years. Later, we met faculty members who had joined other institutes. They reported on the difference Linux and open source makes in trouble-free operation. We then knew we were on a strong footing," recalls Bhavsar.

Bhavsar admits that it was difficult to wean away users who had never worked on Linux. He and his team decided to be the role models, so all IT personnel stopped using Windows before asking others to do so. They then ensured that one of the IT team members would practically hand-hold users through difficult situations. The first thin client was put in Bhavsar's office. Today, he uses a dual boot laptop (Ubuntu and Win XP Pro). "We mostly use XP Pro outside our campus only if external hardware requires it. I have installed FC10 at home for my daughters to use," says Bhavsar.

"We had to set up five machines at a time, make the desktop look like Windows, train users personally, solve all their problems, and move on. We had monthly training sessions for the first six months, besides personally taking care of individual problems on a one-to-one basis. Our slogan was: 'Tell us what you do in Windows that you can't do with open source.' We then identified an appropriate open source tool. We conduct

user training sessions every six months, even now."

All said, I still wondered what the most important attraction of GNU/Linux was. Bhavsar has a simple answer. "Technically, the fact that it's robust, secure and least vulnerable to virus attacks attracted us to the Linux platform. Open source just won our hearts because it is made by altruist individuals and groups with a humanitarian approach. We believe open source can positively change lives in a way few other things can."

Going back to the implementation at ITM, one of the biggest challenges in the world of GNU/Linux is the availability of so many options. What do you have in the proprietary world? Windows or Mac—the devil or the deep blue sea; and that's the end of your options. But with GNU/Linux, the options are unlimited. So, how did Bhavsar and his team find the right solutions for their needs?

"The consultant helped us take the first few steps. Once we implemented one LTSP supporting 20 users (OpenOffice.org, Firefox, Gaim and Thunderbird) we started looking for tools commonly required on educational campuses. The Internet was the best source of information, followed by Linux magazines. Meetings with like-minded people in workshops and seminars also added to our knowledge."

What started at Bhavsar's campus is now spreading to other ITM centres as well. "We now have a few well-trained systems administrators who can independently set up the base systems required by every centre. Our proxy and data servers in Chennai, Bangalore and Warangal use open source only. Other centres are lined up for the transition. We will be adding Intranet servers and NAS (FreeNAS) boxes in each of our centres."

Bhavsar makes it a point to attend any workshop or seminar where open source is showcased. He is particularly interested in spreading this culture in educational institutes, which he feels need it the most. He is also planning to hold workshops at a nominal cost for teachers/professors and IT administrators of educational institutes.

He sums it with, "We are absolutely sure that our model is applicable to any educational institute. Currently, we are concentrating on making all our centres work on FOSS. We would be glad to help train any other educational institute's systems administrator who's willing to come to our Mumbai campus. We would not mind training interested individuals willing to bear the incidental expenses." 

By Swapnil Bhartiya

A Free Software fund-a-mental-ist and Charles Bukowski fan, Swapnil also writes fiction and tries to find cracks in a proprietary company's 'paper armours'. He is a big movie buff, and prefers listening to music at such loud volumes that he's gone partially deaf when it comes to identifying anything positive about proprietary companies. Oh, and he is also the assistant editor of *EFYTimes.com*.